

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 6
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Relearning What Our Souls Already Know
11 October 2026

COMMUNION

Preaching: ML

Worship Leading: Youth and LVF

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[ML & Sarah to center chancel]

Welcome

LVF

Words of Gathering

LVF &...

In the beginning God created all things;

And God said they were good.

At our beginning, God created us,
unique and irreplaceable;

Loved by God, wanted by God,

known to God, and treasured by God.

In every new beginning, God is still present –

creating, transforming, renewing –

calling us into relationship with God,

with each other

and with all of creation.

Will we respond with lives of simplicity and sustainability?

In this sacred time and place,

we pledge ourselves to act for justice

and the healing of the earth.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

OR

Fountain of life...

Pulse of life...

Breath of life...

Earth is filled with the presentness of God.

A planet filled with the presence of God
*a living green blue planet,
people from every corner of creation,
the vast reaches of space above us,
and the rocks and hills and wonders of the wild.*

Together this day,
let us sense and feel
the face of God in all creation.

*Together this day,
let us celebrate the life-giving
breath of our God.*

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn Of Gathering** *Creator of All Time and Space* **TALLIS' CANON**
Creator of all time and space,
we read your image on each face.
Great Spirit of the cosmic whole,
you made us body, mind, and soul.

We thank you for the human mind,
in mystic harmony designed,
for word and image, dream and thought,
for lessons learned and answers sought.

O God of planet, moon, and sun,
we wonder, knowing all you've done,

that you befriend the human race,
and fill our lives with love and grace.

For miracles as large as space,
as small as cells, as deep as grace,
we offer you our thanks and praise,
and pledge to serve you all our days. [-lyrics by Ruth C. Duck]

[Michael center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness

LVF

God of love, show us our place in this world
as channels of your love
for all the creatures of this earth -
for not one of us is forgotten in your sight.

Enlighten those who possess power and money
that they may avoid indifference,
that they may love the common good,
advance the weak,
and care for this world
in which we live.
The poor, the oppressed, and the earth
are crying out.

So we ask, Good and Gracious God, seize us with your power,
with your beautiful darkness, with your amazing light,
and help us to protect all life,
with all that we have and all that we are
as we work for your kin-dom
of justice, peace, love, and beauty.

-adapted from the Pope's Encyclical, 2015

Amen and Amen.

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

[...to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

LVF

As we share this ancient greeting,
we invite you to offer signs of peace to one another with a bow
- a gesture used broadly across many cultures
as a sign of greeting, respect, honor, humility, and love.
This morning, may it be an expression
of the intention of the peace with which we long to live
with one another, the world, and all creation.

Let there be
respect for the earth
peace for its people
delight in the good
forgiveness for past wrongs
and from now on a new start.

[ChurchesTogetherinEngland]

This morning may the peace of God be with you.

And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with those seated near you...

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.

And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[... to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

This is the witness of the ancients...

Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Michael to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

LVF

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Each one of us knows things in the core of our being
that we have not necessarily been taught,
and some of this deep knowing may actually
be at odds with what our society or religion
has tried to teach us.

In this time, in this brave space we call home,
we are being invited to reawaken
to what we know in the depths of our being -
that the earth is sacred and that this sacredness
is at the heart of every human being and life-form.

As we are now in silence together,
let us breathe in this sacred space
knowing that God is with us
in this time and place. [jphilipnewell]

Silence

[Christoph plays transition out of silence]

Prayer of our Hearts

Creator Spirit,
we give thanks that your life-giving Presence
has been active in our universe for all the billions of years
that have passed since the first moments of its existence.

Working within and with what was there,
your Presence came to visible expression
in the formation of stars
and galaxies
and planets.

Rocks and grasses,
water and soil,

all living things, including us,
came to life with a conscious
awareness and appreciation
of your Presence.

Help us on this day
to marvel at this life,
even though we do not know where or how it started.

*Help us on this day
to celebrate the Source of all that is
and of all that shall be. Amen.* [mmorwood/adapt]

[2 minutes of silence, then Christoph transition out of silence]

Prayer of Our Hearts

[Christoph transition for Laude]

Meditation Anthem

[Christoph transition Michael to pulpit]

Sermon *Relearning What Our Souls Already Know* **ML**

[Christoph transition as Michael & Laura go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings **LVF & ML**

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We are drawn together by the Wisdom of the universe,
nature's intelligence,
embodied in Jesus
and present in all souls
who gather at Wisdom's table.

*We gather to receive grace to give up our foolish ways,
to walk in Wisdom's light,
to delight in creation and in one another,
as the Holy One delights in us.*

May we open the gates of our souls, that Wisdom may enter,
making us friends of God and one another.

*We open in this time to the
transforming power of the Spirit.*

You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith, or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[... to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

Each morning brings us a newness
that we but need to step into.
It can wash us,
lift us,
heal us,
hold us
just as each of us has need.

As we give from our financial resources this morning,
to continue the work of this church
may we be open to the power that lies within us.
May we be full with a confidence in our strength.
May we move from empty routines
to the fullness of life
that we might live God's dream.

You will find information for online giving in your programs and appearing on your screens at home. Our Hospitality Team will also come forward now to receive your offerings. Thank you for your ongoing generosity through the resources, time, and talents you bring to strengthen our community to be the Love of the Divine in the world.

Offertory

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Sarah to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

Holy One, as we give our offerings
may our eyes be open
to see you in all the colors of creation
as you use our generosity to awaken us
to a new sense of awe and wonder.

May we know you, O God, as the sacred presence that is real to us.
May we know you, O God, as the one who is the source of inspiration
and courage as you keep calling us forward
to share your dream for our world.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Amen.

Please be seated

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF & ML

Words of Blessing

ML

As we leave this place we make sacred by our presence,
may we be wholly present in our own lives,
ready to be surprised
by the wonder of each ordinary moment.

***May the light around us guide our footsteps,
may the darkness around us
nurture our dreams and give us rest.***

May it be so.

May it be so for us!

Choral Response

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn for the Journey *Wake Now My Senses

SLANE

Wake now my senses, and hear the Earth call,
feel the deep power of being in all,
keep with the web of creation your vow,
giving, receiving, as love shows us how.

Wake now my reason, reach out for the new,
join with each trav'ler who quests for the true,
honor the beauty and wisdom of time,
transcend our limits and touch the sublime.

Wake now my vision, the dream we hold dear,
brighten our pathway with radiance here,
journey together with all who will share,
love for the planet transformed by our care.

--lyrics Mikelson

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music